



FIGB

LESSON 100: THE FIRST TRICK

1 THE THINKING PAUSE

at the first trick is essential.



2 DEDUCTIONS

from the opening lead and the bidding.



OPENING LEAD WHAT CAN WE DEDUCE?

3 NORMAL OPENING LEAD RULES

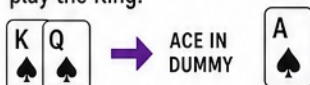
- Not under an Ace in trump.
- From a sequence.
- From partner's suit.



4 UNBLOCKING HONORS

at the first trick:

If you have KQ doubleton and the Ace is in the dummy, play the King!



PLAY THE KING!

5 SUSPECT UNUSUAL LEADS:

when the opponent does not lead normally, look for a ruff!



6 STOP! THINK!

Take time before you play. A good decision on the first trick can make the contract!



STOP! THINK!

THE FIRST TRICK

Set the tone for the whole hand!

NORTH (DUMMY)

♠ A K J 10 4
♥ Q 8 6 2
♦ A 9 5
♣ 9 6 3

SOUTH (DECLARER)

♠ Q 9 3 2
♥ A J 10 7 3
♦ K Q 8 4
♣ K 10 5

OPENING LEAD



WEST

EAST

THE BIDDING

WEST NORTH EAST SOUTH

- - - 1♥

PASS 1♠ PASS 2NT

PASS 3NT PASS PASS

PASS



Use the bidding to help make deductions about partner's hand!

WHAT IS PARTNER'S HOLDING?

REMEMBER

- ✓ Think before you play.
- ✓ Make deductions.
- ✓ Look for danger.
- ✓ Find the best line from the very first trick!

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Lesson 101:

5-3 Fit and 4-4 Fit

1 TWO WAYS TO PLAY WITH TRUMPS



CONTROL OF THE HAND

Draw trumps, then cash the long suits.



TOTAL RUFFING

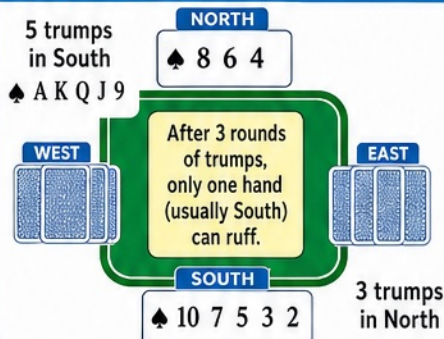
Ruff from both hands.

2 BASE HAND

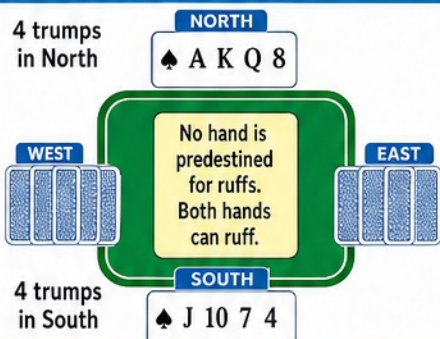
The one that draws the opponents' trumps (usually the longest in trumps).



3 5-3 FIT: THE MOST DELICATE



4 4-4 FIT: THE MOST POWERFUL



5 DEFENSE AGAINST SHORTENING



Refuse to ruff from the long hand!

Keep your long trumps for later.

6 5-3 FIT VS 4-4 FIT: COMPARATIVE CHART

FEATURE	5-3 FIT	4-4 FIT
TRUMP DISTRIBUTION	5-3 (uneven) ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠	4-4 (even) ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠ ♠
RUFFING POTENTIAL	Limited Only one hand can ruff early.	High Both hands can ruff.
POWER	Less powerful Dependent on trump control.	More powerful Greater flexibility and strength.
RISK	Higher Danger of being short in ruffs.	Lower Safer and more balanced.
BEST PLAN	Usually control: Draw trumps, then cash winners.	Usually total ruffing: Ruff from both hands.

7 EXAMPLE: HOW THE 4-4 FIT PRODUCES MORE TRICKS

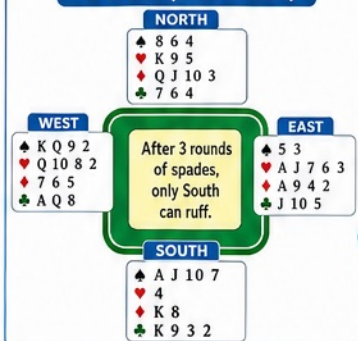
CONTRACT: 4♠
TRUMP: SPADES

♠ Spades
♥ Hearts
♦ Diamonds
♣ Clubs

TRICKS MADE
= 9 TRICKS

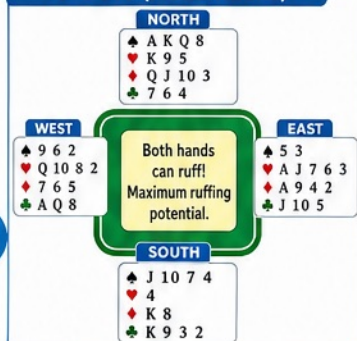
2 spade ruffs
+ 7 other tricks

5-3 FIT (LESS TRICKS)



VS

4-4 FIT (MORE TRICKS)



TRICKS MADE
= 11 TRICKS

4 spade ruffs
+ 7 other tricks



Even distribution (4-4 fit) gives you more options and more tricks.
Learn when to control the trumps and when to ruff everything!

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LESSON 102:

DEFENSE -

FIGB COUNT AND SUIT PREFERENCE

1. COUNTING THE CARDS

METHOD	WHAT TO DO	EXAMPLE	MEANING
HIGH-LOW (8 then 3)	Play a HIGH card first, then a LOWER card.	8♠ → 3♠	EVEN number of cards
LOW-HIGH (3 then 8)	Play a LOW card first, then a HIGHER card.	3♠ → 8♠	ODD number of cards

2. SEQUENCES TAKE PRECEDENCE OVER COUNT



→ Play Q

A sequence is more important than count.



→ Play 10

A sequence is more important than count.

3. SUIT PREFERENCE SIGNAL



HIGH card = **HIGHER** ranking suit
prefer the



LOW card = **LOWER** ranking suit
prefer the

4. WHEN to give COUNT



When partner has already decided what to do in the suit.

5. WHEN to give SUIT PREFERENCE



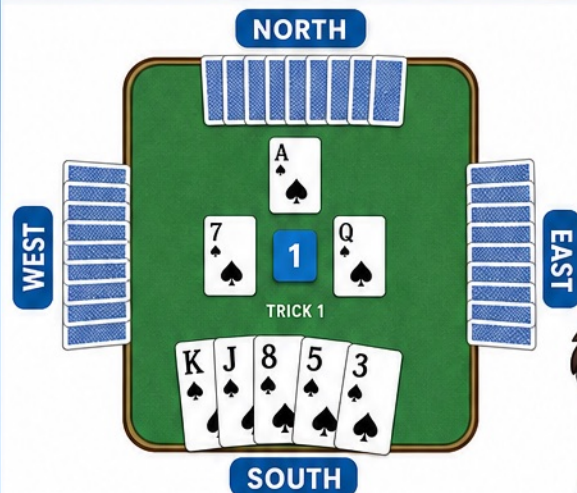
When partner needs to choose which suit to play.

6. CAUTION



Do not give **COUNT** when it only helps the declarer!

7. PRACTICAL EXAMPLE: DEFENDER CHOOSING WHICH CARD TO PLAY



Partner (East) led the Queen of Spades. I must decide which card to play.



If I play **HIGH** (8), I prefer the **HIGHER** ranking suit for partner to continue.



If I play **LOW** (3), I prefer the **LOWER** ranking suit for partner to continue.

Right now, partner needs to choose a suit, so I can give **SUIT PREFERENCE** with my card.



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Lesson 103:

Defense - Suits to Move with Urgency

1



ANTICIPATE

suits where you can
ESTABLISH TRICKS
before the declarer discards.

TIME IS IMPORTANT!

2



IMAGINE THE HONORS:

a challenging but
essential operation
for defense.

3



"NO PARKING" SUIT:

must be removed
urgently before the
declarer discards
losers.

4



COUNT THE DECLARER'S CARDS

to understand if they
have available discards.

5

AGGRESSIVE vs NEUTRAL OPENING LEAD



AGGRESSIVE:

when time
is running out,
take risks to
establish.



NEUTRAL:

when the
contract is
not in danger,
play passively.

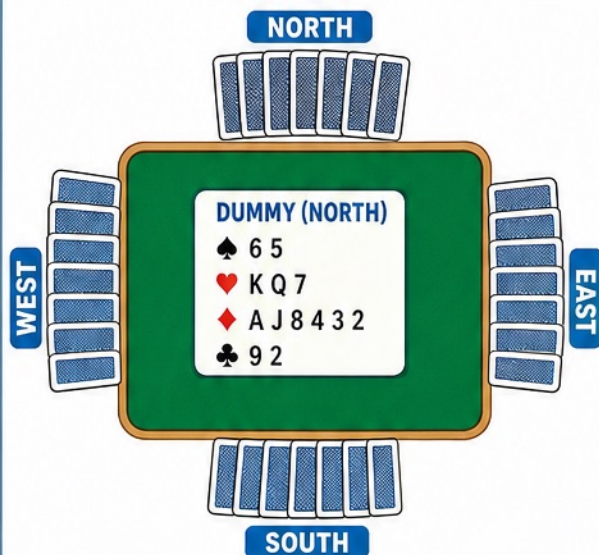
6

DUMMY WITH A LONG SUIT THAT CAN BE ESTABLISHED = URGENCY FOR DEFENDERS!



Act now, before the
declarer discards
from the long suit!

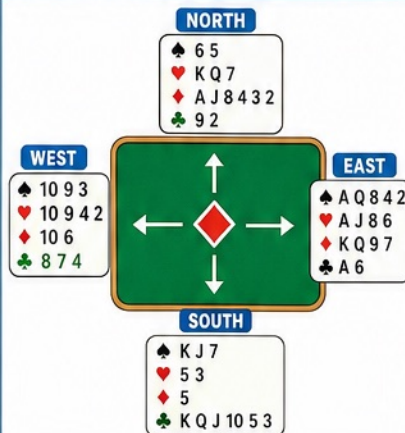
DIAGRAM: ESTABLISH THE LONG SUIT



Dummy has a long Diamond suit
that can be established.

Move Diamonds with urgency!

EXAMPLE: LEAD THE WEAK SUIT IMMEDIATELY



WHAT IS HAPPENING?

If you wait, declarer
will discard a losing
Diamond from
Dummy and the long
Diamond suit becomes
wasted.



RIGHT LEAD

Lead a weak suit
(such as a Club)
now, before the
declarer discards
from Dummy.



GOOD DEFENSE = ANTICIPATION + TIMING

Don't give the declarer the time they need!



Lesson 104: SAFETY PLAYS

1. VOLUNTARY LOSS

of a trick to secure
the contract



★ 2. GOLDEN RULE

“If you need **N** tricks,
play for **N**,
not for **N+1**”



THINK SAFE!

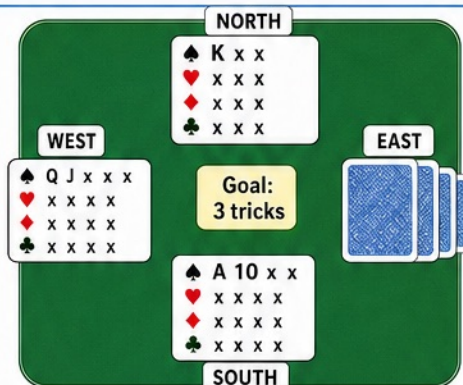
Avoid disaster.
Make your
contract.

3 EXAMPLE 1

A10xx opposite Kxx
(8 cards, goal 3 tricks)

SAFETY PLAY:

- Play small towards the 10.
- If West covers with J or Q, win with K.
- If not covered, insert 10.
- Lose **max 1** trick against QJxxx in West.



HOW IT WORKS

- 1 South plays a small spade towards 10.
10 ← small
 - 2 If West covers with J or Q, win with K.
K ← Q or J
 - 3 If not covered, insert 10 and win the trick.
10 → small
- Lose **max 1** trick
against QJxxx in West.

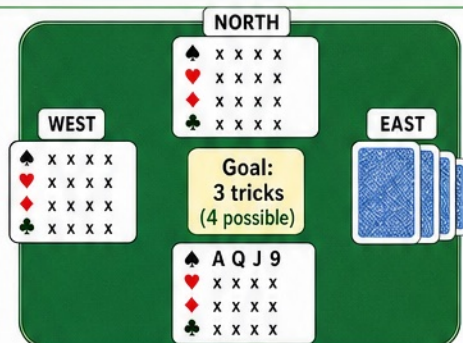
4 EXAMPLE 2

AQJ9 opposite xxxx
(8 cards, goal 3 tricks,
4 possible)

- Simple finesse = 50%
for 4 tricks.

SAFETY PLAY for 3 sure:

- Cash Ace.
- Then play small towards Q.
- Lose **max 1**.



HOW IT WORKS

- 1 Cash the Ace.
A → win
 - 2 Play a small spade
towards Q.
Q ← small
 - 3 If West has Q, you win.
If not, you lose **max 1**.
- You make **3** sure.
4 tricks are possible.

5 EXAMPLE 3

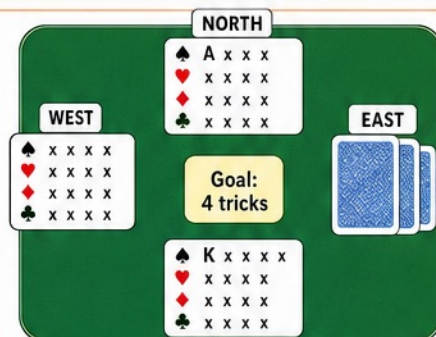
Kxxxx opposite Axxx
(9 cards, goal 4 tricks)

NATURAL LINE:

- Ace, King, small.
- Works if 3-1.
- **Risk** if 4-0.

SAFETY PLAY:

- Play small from dummy.
- Delay inserting the honor.
- Works against 4-0.



HOW IT WORKS

NATURAL LINE (RISKY):

- A → K → small
Works if 3-1.
Risk if West has all 4.

SAFETY PLAY (SAFER):

- small → small → then insert honor
Delay the honor.
This works against 4-0.

Make **4** tricks safely.

DECISION DIAGRAM



Do you need
X tricks?

YES

Use a
SAFETY PLAY

NO

Use the
MAXIMUM LINE



MOTTO

The **SAFETY PLAY**
pays a small premium
to **avoid disaster!**

Lesson 105: Probabilities and Percentages

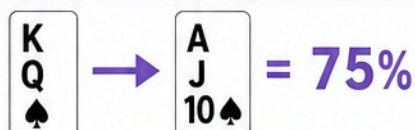
1 DISTRIBUTION TABLE

MISSING CARDS	POSSIBLE SPLITS	EXAMPLE DIAGRAM	PROBABILITY
6 missing	3-3	♥♥♥ ♥♥♥	36%
	4-2	♥♥♥♥ ♥♥	48%
	5-1	♥♥♥♥♥ ♥	15%
	6-0	♥♥♥♥♥♥ -	1%
5 missing	3-2	♠♠♠ ♠♠	68%
	4-1	♠♠♠♠ ♠	28%
	5-0	♠♠♠♠♠ -	4%
4 missing	3-1	♦♦♦ ♦	50%
	2-2	♦♦ ♦♦	40%
	4-0	♦♦♦♦ -	10%

2 FINESSE

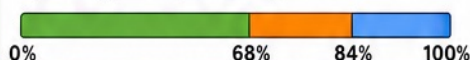


2B DOUBLE FINESSE (AJ10)

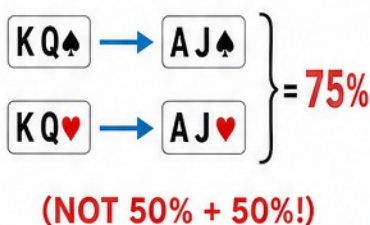


3 SUCCESSIVE CHANCES ADD UP

$$68\% \text{ (first try)} + 16\% \text{ (second try)} = 84\%$$



4 TWO FINESSES, ONLY NEED ONE!



5 PLAY ORDER

FIRST THE CHANCE THAT
DOES NOT BURN
THE OTHER.

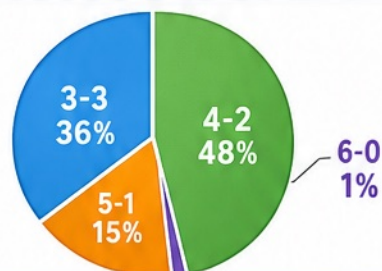


SAFE
FIRST

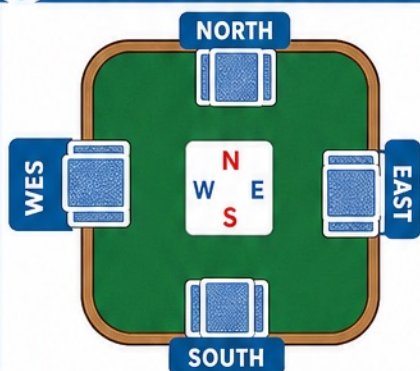


BURNS
IF IT FAILS

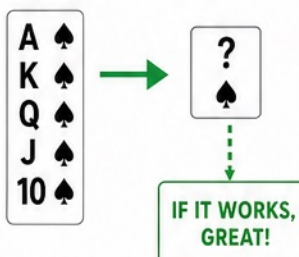
6 DISTRIBUTION PIE CHART (6 MISSING)



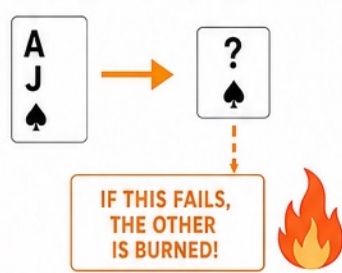
7 FIRST TRY THE LONG ONE (COSTS NOTHING), THEN THE FINESSE (BURNS!)



1. TRY THE LONG ONE (COSTS NOTHING)



2. THEN THE FINESSE (BURNS IF IT FAILS)



Lesson 106: To Cover or Not to Cover

Do I cover or not?

1



SMALL ON SMALL:

general rule when a low card is led from the dummy.

2



HONOR ON HONOR:

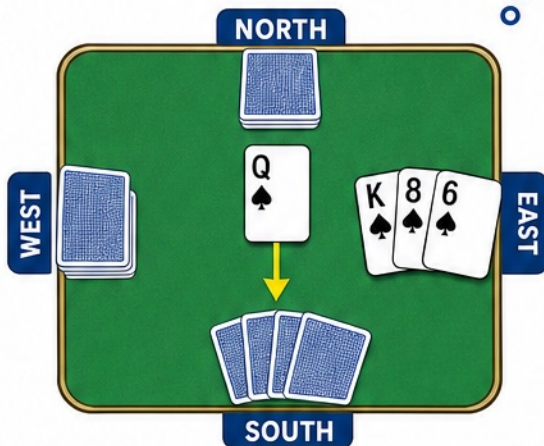
cover only if you hope to **ESTABLISH** a lower card.

3



WITH A SOLID SEQUENCE:

play the highest.
(e.g., QJ10 → play Q)



4



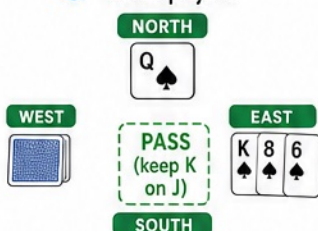
TWO HONORS IN THE DUMMY: DO NOT cover the FIRST, cover the SECOND!

- Example: QJ in the dummy, you have Kxx in East.

♠ North plays Q → **PASS** (keep K on J).

♠ If North plays J next → **COVER** with K.

1 North plays Q



2 North plays J



Note: if East has AKxxx, never cover: Ace captures the suit anyway.



5



LENGTH FACTOR:

with long cards under the honor, more reason to cover.



More cards under the King = more reason to cover.



SUMMARY CHART

ALWAYS COVER



- Honor on honor when you need to establish a lower card.
- When you have a very long sequence under the honor.
- When partner has shown shortage in the suit.

NEVER COVER



- Two honors in the dummy – first honor led.
- When you have Ace-K (or Ace alone).
- When covering achieves nothing (no lower card to establish).

IT DEPENDS



- Intermediate length under the honor.
- Unclear dummy holding.
- Consider score, risk, and overall contract.

LESSON 107: ELIMINATION PLAYS

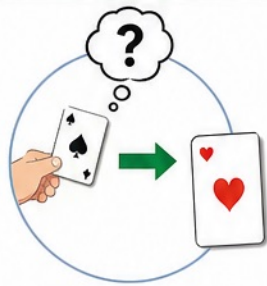
1. PRINCIPLE



REMOVE ALL **SAFE EXITS** FOR THE OPPONENT,
THEN **GIVE** THEM THE TRICK.



2. RUFF AND DISCARD



DEFENDER
FORCED TO PLAY
A SUIT THAT IS
VOID → DECLARER
**RUFFS AND
DISCARDS.**

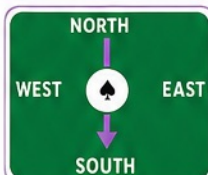
4. PREPARATION

- 1  ELIMINATE
SIDE SUITS.
- 2  DRAW
OPPONENTS'
TRUMPS.
- 3  RUFF THE REMAINS
OF ELIMINATED
SUITS.
- 4  GIVE UP
THE TRICK!

3. DELICATE HOLDINGS

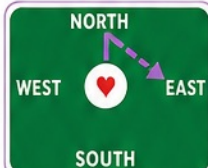
1 ♠ A 10 3
♥ J 6 3

**ELIMINATE
THEN GIVE,**
OPPONENT
MUST PLAY
THE SUIT.



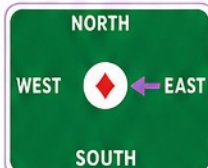
2 ♠ A J 3
♥ K 10 2

**ELIMINATION
CREATES AN
AUTOMATIC
FINESSE.**



3 ♠ K 10 3
♥ Q 9 2

**OPPONENT
MUST LEAD
THE SUIT.**



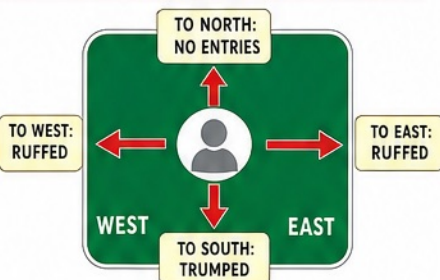
5. AT 3NT WITHOUT A RUFF

3NT

**FORCE A LEAD
IN A FAVORABLE
SUIT.**



6. OPPONENT "TRAPPED"



NOWHERE SAFE TO GO!

7. THE ELIMINATION SEQUENCE

- 1 **ELIMINATE
SIDE SUITS.**

Remove all
safe exits.
- 2 **DRAW
TRUMPS.**

Take control
of the trumps.
- 3 **RUFF
REMAINS.**

Ruff the last
of the suits.
- 4 **GIVE UP
THE TRICK.**

Now it's safe
to give it up!
- 5 **OPPONENT
IS FORCED.**

They must play
the suit you
want.



REMEMBER: ELIMINATE, DRAW, RUFF, THEN GIVE!

Take away the escapes, then lead them where you want.

Lesson 108: Play As If



1



ASSUME

the necessary conditions for success.

2



DON'T DELAY:

if the finesse **MUST** work, do it **NOW** (not later).

3



ORDER:

start with the most **RISKY** suit (the one that can go wrong).

4



DISCARD LOSING HYPOTHESES:

if a distribution will make you go down anyway, don't worry about it.

5



ANALYSIS OF NECESSARY HYPOTHESES:

- 1 What **MUST** be true for the contract to succeed?
- 2 → List of conditions
- 3 → Eliminate the impossible ones
- 4 → Play **AS IF** the remaining ones were true.

5

ANALYSIS OF NECESSARY HYPOTHESES



What **MUST** be true for the contract to succeed?



List of conditions

- Condition 1
- Condition 2
- Condition 3
- ...



Eliminate the impossible ones.



Play **AS IF** the remaining ones were true.

Hypothesis A:
contract made



Hypothesis B:
contract down anyway



CHOOSE A!

PRACTICAL EXAMPLE: ASSUME THE KING ON THE LEFT AND PLAY ACCORDINGLY



THE SITUATION

You are South.
Contract: 4♥

You need hearts to break 3-3.
There is a chance the King of Hearts is on your left (West).

OUR NECESSARY HYPOTHESES

- The King of Hearts is on West.
- Hearts break 3-3.
- All other suits behave.



PLAY AS IF THESE ARE TRUE!

Take the finesse now while the entry (♣ A) is safe.

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ K J 10 6	♠ Q 5	♠ 9 7 4 3	♠ A 8 2
♥ Q J 7 5	♥ 2	♥ K 10 8 4	♥ A 9 6 3
♦ A Q 9 6	♦ 3 2	♦ J 7 5	♦ K 10 8 4
♣ 9 4 2	♣ A J 6 3	♣ Q 7 5	♣ K 10 8

WEST: 4♥ EAST: 4♥

We **ASSUME** the King of Hearts is on West and play accordingly.

HOW TO PLAY

- 1 Cash the ♣ A.



- 2 Lead a heart toward the King.



- 3 West wins with the K♥.



- 4 Continue hearts. Hearts break 3-3, and the contract is made!



Lesson 109: Declarer's Deductions

1 DEDUCTIONS FROM THE OPENING LEAD:

NT

No Trump:

- fourth longest suit
- high lead = sequence
- low lead = honor above



♠

Trump:

- sequence
- short for ruff
- partner's suit



2 PASSER DOES NOT HAVE THE OPENING:



PASS

If opponent has passed, they have less than 12 points → distribute the points!

3 COUNT THE SHOWN POINTS:



Every time an opponent plays an honor, note it mentally.

4 DEDUCTION ON DISTRIBUTION:



- From the type of opening (1♥ = 5+ Hearts, 1NT = balanced 15–17)
- From the type of response
- From defensive signals

5 DO NOT TAKE LOSING FINESSES:

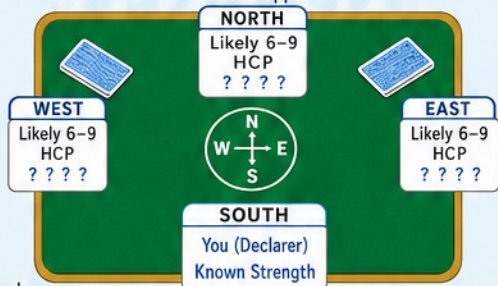


If you know the King is on the right, do not finesse to the left!



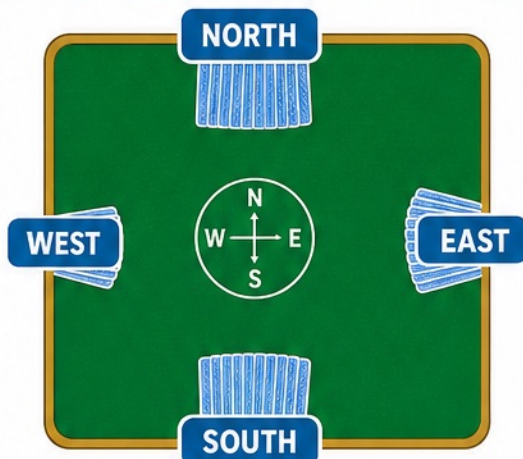
6 DECLARER'S MENTAL MAP:

A Picture of the Deduced Opponents' Points



Keep updating your mental map as the hand progresses!

BRIDGE TABLE: FOUR POSITIONS



Good declarers collect clues, make deductions, and create a plan!

7 EXAMPLE: SOUTH DEFENDER WITH 11 HCP

South's Hand (11 HCP)

♠ A J 8 5
♥ Q 7 4 3
♦ K 6 2
♣ 9 4

A = 4
K = 3
Q = 2
J = 1

Total = 11

WEST OPENS 1NT (15–17, BALANCED)



South knows West is balanced with 15–17 points.
South has 11 points.
So, the other 3 honors (4 points) are in North or East.

WHERE ARE THE MISSING HONORS?

Honor	West	North	East
♠	A J	?	?
♥	Q	?	?
♦	K	?	?
♣	—	?	?
Points	10–12	0–4	0–4

North and East share the remaining 3–7 points.



Use the opening bid, the play, and the signals to refine your deductions!



OBSERVE • DEDUCE • PLAN • SUCCEED!

Maestro Franci